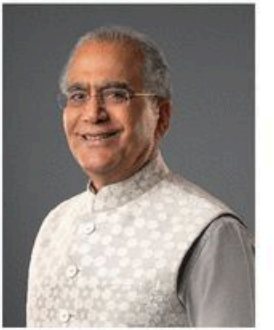
46TH ANNIVERSARY

FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF



The first edition of INDIA TODAY hit the stands in the silver jubilee year of our Republic. Three years from now, when the Republic is 75, we will celebrate half a century of our existence. What an incredible journey it has been. We have covered the highs and lows of India's roller-coaster ride of the past few decades, from the Emergency to the pandemic, without missing a single edition. The anniversary issue of the magazine is often a time for us to reflect. Our previous issues have looked at the significant events of the past decade, the life-changing moments of top personalities and the changes in rural India.

We are also conscious that we live in the youngest country among major economies—half of India is under 29. The youth account for one-fifth of the world's population. Our youth bulge thus is one of our greatest assets, and what they do individually or collectively will decide where we are as a nation in the years ahead. So, for our 46th anniversary, we decided to look at India tomorrow—the men and women who were not even born when our magazine was launched and yet who are set to excel in their respective fields.

THE NEXT 100

We have chosen a hundred young men and women who will be the future stars of this country. 'The Next 100', as we have called them, have already made their mark as leaders, scientists, writers, artists, sportspersons and entrepreneurs. Many have rewritten the rules of the game. It took Reliance and Infosys a generation to become two of India's most valuable companies. Byju Raveendran, 40, needed just a decade to turn Byju's into the world's biggest edtech company, with a market cap of $21 billion (Rs 1.6 lakh crore) in August. In the assembly election held in Bihar in 2020, 32-year-old Tejashwi Yadav, pitted against two heavyweight ruling parties, came within a whisker of becoming one of India's youngest chief ministers—he is currently the opposition leader in the assembly. This year, Neeraj Chopra, 23, threw a javelin to Olympic gold, living up to the Games' faster, higher, stronger motto. He is one of our most significant sporting sensations of the year and among those to watch out for in the years ahead. Entertainer Bhuvan Bam enjoys the kind of adulation on YouTube that Amitabh Bachchan did at the box office in the year of our launch.

Then there are the young entrepreneurs who have spun their ideas into successful businesses, be it Ankit Mehta, 32, whose startup Idea Forge has become India's most prominent drone firm. Or Avarna Jain, director of Saregama, who has turned a retro-looking music player into a household name and the largest repository of music in India. Or space entrepreneur Pawan Kumar Chandana, 32, who plans to launch a satellite from a privately-built rocket in 2022. Radhika Gupta, 38, the MD and CEO of Edelweiss AMC, is one of India's most influential businesswomen.

Others have seen opportunity in the crisis brought about by Covid. Ayushi Gudwani, 37, diversified her businesswear line for women into accessories during the pandemic. Tejasvi Surya, 31, the BJP's youngest Lok Sabha MP, set up a Covid task force to deliver medical aid and provisions to his constituents.

The trailblazers are followed by a generation of equally successful young Indians aged 16 to 18. At 242 million, India has the world's largest population of those aged between 10 and 24. This cohort is far bigger than China's 185 million young people. We asked them what India meant to them. Riddhiman Ganguly, a 17-year-old student from Kolkata, said he wanted an India where 'the marble floors of shrines are sacred, but so is the land, water and air'.

However, any such listing cannot be exhaustive. It can only indicate that India is teeming with young talent and boundless energy in almost every field, a generation that can stand up to the best in the world. They are the future of the country. The heartening part is that they radiate optimism, confidence and ambition. To them, there is nothing that is not possible. There is a lot wrong in our country, but these young men and women give me hope that our future will be bright.

On that note, I would like to wish you all a healthy, happy and prosperous 2022. We definitely need it.

(Aroon Purie)